

Climate, Wildlife, Animal Science, and Clean Tech: The Week of August 30-September 5, 2026

This week's biggest story was a genuinely contested one: reporting that the federal government has been discussing a land exchange to give a piece of Yosemite National Park to a private developer, which the Interior Department disputes was pursued secretly or under political pressure. Elsewhere, state legislatures moved on climate bills, Indonesia's wildfire haze crisis kept intensifying, and a small Philippine deer's genome offered a rare piece of good news for endangered-species genetics. Sourcing is noted throughout, since several items rely on claims from advocacy groups, agencies, or single reports rather than settled fact.

Climate Policy

Trump administration weighs Yosemite land swap; Interior disputes how the story has been framed. Reporting first published by NOTUS on August 28, and followed through this week by the Washington Post, CNBC, Newsweek, and the San Francisco Chronicle, revealed that the National Park Service has been discussing a land exchange that would give a company tied to Nevada-based Kingsbarn Realty Capital an access road — “under a mile,” per Kingsbarn’s attorney — connecting its 83-acre property (known historically as Hazel Green Ranch, just outside Yosemite’s western boundary) to Yosemite’s Big Oak Flat Road. In exchange, Kingsbarn would purchase land of equal value elsewhere in California and hand it to the Park Service. Some reporting describes the swap as involving a roughly quarter-mile strip of park land or an easement over it; critics note this kind of exchange, which federal law permits without a congressional vote, has historically been used to bring land *into* parks rather than give park land away.

What’s disputed is not whether discussions are happening — Kingsbarn’s attorney, Lanny Davis, has confirmed the company is pursuing an exchange, and the Interior Department itself has confirmed talks are underway — but how those discussions are being characterized. NOTUS’s original report, citing anonymous current and former officials, said Interior leadership pressured Park Service staff to move the deal forward and that it had proceeded with unusual secrecy. The Interior Department pushed back directly: a spokesperson called that framing “anonymous allegations to manufacture a political narrative that simply is not true,” stated “there has been no political pressure to reach a predetermined outcome,” and said “no final decisions have been made,” adding that any exchange would go through required environmental review and public notice. Kingsbarn’s attorney separately said the arrangement is “a land exchange under the law” that “will not reduce the land area of the park.” Rep. Jared Huffman (D-CA) has criticized the proposal as land “sold off to Trump’s ultra-wealthy friends” — a characterization from a critic, not a neutral description. In short: an exchange is genuinely being discussed and hasn’t been finalized, but whether it was pursued secretly or under political

pressure is contested between anonymous sources on one side and an on-record agency denial on the other.

State legislatures moved on climate bills. California’s legislative session closed this week with lawmakers sending a package of climate and energy bills to Governor Newsom’s desk, according to the League of Conservation Voters’ weekly roundup (citing Utility Dive reporting). The bills include a data-center guardrails package requiring operators to cover their own energy costs rather than passing them to ratepayers, along with measures on building electrification, mandatory environmental review for polluting facilities, expanded solar access, and increased oversight of utility spending; all still need the governor’s signature. Separately, New Jersey Governor Mikie Sherrill signed a law requiring data centers to disclose their energy and water use, completing what her office described as a four-part data center policy plan.

Wildlife & Conservation

- **Indonesia’s wildfire haze crisis intensified and spread.** Mongabay reported September 4 that smoke from Indonesian wildfires — fueled by a “super” El Niño — had spread beyond Malaysia and Brunei to reach Singapore and the Philippines, with satellite monitoring platform Firewatch detecting more than 444,200 fire hotspots as of September 3, 4.5 times the count from late July. Indonesian officials say many fires were deliberately set, and environmental group WALHI found roughly half the hotspots in West and Central Kalimantan fell within oil palm and timber concessions. The toll on wildlife has been direct: firefighters found snake and pangolin carcasses in burned areas, and a rescued Borneo orangutan died of suspected smoke inhalation days after being found at an oil palm plantation, according to Indonesian forestry authorities cited by Mongabay.
- **British Columbia weighs extending its wolf cull.** The provincial government is deciding whether to extend, by five more years, a decade-old program that has killed roughly 2,844 wolves and 51 cougars via aerial gunning to protect endangered woodland caribou, according to CBC News and Mongabay reporting this week (Sept. 1-2). Critics — including the group Pacific Wild, which cites its own recent survey finding about three-quarters of British Columbians oppose any wolf killing — argue the province continues issuing logging permits in caribou habitat even as it culls the caribou’s predators, calling habitat loss the real driver of decline. A provincial spokesperson said a final decision is expected by October. This directly follows last week’s report of a First Nations petition for emergency protection of one of the same herds.
- **A window into the illegal coral trade.** A Mongabay feature published August 31 described how the Georgia Aquarium has taken in more than 500 illegally trafficked coral specimens confiscated by the U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service, offering a rare look at the scale of an illicit trade that receives far less attention than wildlife trafficking in animals.

Animal Health & Field Science

- **A genetic breakthrough for an endangered Philippine deer.** Researchers at Silliman University and the Philippine Genome Center Visayas sequenced the

first-ever draft genome of the Visayan spotted deer, a species found only on two Philippine islands with roughly 700 mature individuals left in the wild, Mongabay reported September 4. The genome — 2.5 billion DNA letters, sequenced from a captive deer named Abraham — revealed a heterozygosity score of just 0.17, well below the 0.3 typical of healthy wild populations, indicating inbreeding in the captive colony. Researchers identified a rare genetic marker in one still-reproductively-active individual that could help guide a new genome-based captive breeding program, replacing the pedigree-tracing method used until now.

- **Ebola outbreak in the DRC underscores the human-wildlife health link.** The Bundibugyo-strain Ebola outbreak in the Democratic Republic of Congo — now the largest Ebola outbreak ever recorded in DRC — had reached 6,342 confirmed cases and 3,072 deaths as of September 2, according to the European Centre for Disease Prevention and Control’s September 3 situation report, which draws on figures from DRC’s health ministry; WHO and CDC data corroborate the same scale. Mongabay reported September 3 that food insecurity affecting roughly 26 million people in the region is compounding both the outbreak’s spread and its lethality, according to WHO Director-General Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus. Because Ebola is zoonotic and food scarcity pushes more people to hunt bushmeat in forests like Virunga National Park, the outbreak also raises transmission risk to wildlife — between 2002 and 2003, roughly 5,000 western lowland gorillas died from an Ebola outbreak in the Republic of Congo, per past Mongabay reporting. A veterinarian with the Gorilla Doctors program in the DRC told Mongabay that human and wildlife health “are interdependent.”

Clean Technology

- **Federal transmission policy drew criticism as a setback.** The Climate Tech & Clean Energy Monthly Report, published September 1, characterized the Department of Energy’s August 12 cancellation of three National Interest Electric Transmission Corridor designations as the month’s most consequential clean-energy policy setback, arguing transmission siting remains the binding constraint on integrating more renewables — a characterization from a single industry newsletter’s analysis rather than a government assessment.
- **Solar-plus-storage investment hit a record.** The same report, citing BloombergNEF data from late August, found global co-located solar-plus-storage investment reached \$25 billion in the first half of 2026, nearly triple the same period last year, while U.S. renewable investment overall rose 54% year-on-year; separately, EIA data cited in the report put U.S. utility-scale battery storage at roughly 52 GW by mid-2026, up from 43.6 GW at the end of 2025.
- **Brazil moved to regulate rare earth mining.** Brazil’s Senate passed a bill September 3 (per Associated Press, via Mongabay) establishing a legal framework and tax incentives for domestic critical-mineral processing; the bill now awaits President Lula’s signature. Brazil holds the world’s second-largest rare earth reserves, and the move is widely read as an attempt to offer an alternative to China’s dominance of a supply chain feeding EVs, wind turbines, and other clean-tech hardware.
- **New project activity abroad.** Trade outlet Renewable Watch reported a 347-

MW solar project breaking ground in Texas (OCI Energy and Arava Power, Sept. 4), a completed green hydrogen electrolyzer at a Romanian refinery (OMV Petrom, Sept. 2), and continued attention to India's push for domestic battery manufacturing as part of its energy transition (Sept. 3).

The Big Picture

The Yosemite story is, at this point, a genuinely open question rather than a settled scandal: a land exchange is being discussed, both the Interior Department and Kingsbarn confirm that much, but whether it was pursued secretly or under political pressure — the more explosive part of the original reporting — is contested by an on-record agency denial. It's worth watching for how it resolves, particularly since it surfaced the same week California and New Jersey lawmakers were moving in the opposite direction, tightening rather than loosening environmental and energy oversight at the state level. Indonesia's worsening wildfire haze and the DRC's Ebola outbreak were both reminders that the boundary between human and wildlife wellbeing is often thinner than policy debates suggest — smoke that kills orangutans also sickens people across four countries, and a disease outbreak driven partly by food insecurity carries real transmission risk back into gorilla populations. Against that backdrop, the deer genome breakthrough in the Philippines stood out as a rare case of a very specific scientific tool — a full genome sequence — offering an actual practical path forward for a single endangered species. None of this week's threads are resolved; several will likely develop further in the weeks ahead.

Sources

Yosemite land exchange: NOTUS, "Trump Is Quietly Working to Give Part of Yosemite to a Private Developer," Anna Kramer, Aug. 28, 2026; Interior Department on-record statements as reported by the San Francisco Chronicle ("Trump administration denies secret Yosemite land trade reports"), CNBC, and Newsweek ("Map Shows Property at Center of Proposed Yosemite Land Exchange"), all Aug. 29–30, 2026; Sierra News Online, "Proposed Yosemite Land Swap Revives Decades-Old Hazel Green Dispute"; League of Conservation Voters weekly roundup, citing The Guardian, Aug. 28, 2026 (Rep. Huffman quote).

State climate legislation: League of Conservation Voters, "This Week in Climate Action – September 3, 2026," citing Utility Dive and EnviroVoters; NJ.com/TAPinto coverage of NJ data center transparency law.

Wildlife & conservation: Mongabay — "As Indonesia's wildfires rage, haze spreads farther across Southeast Asia" (Yenni Kwok, Sept. 4, 2026); "As British Columbia mulls continued wolf-killing to save caribou, critics say habitat loss is the real threat" (Spoorthy Raman, Sept. 1–2, 2026), also covered by CBC News; "The world's reefs are disappearing. Coral trafficking is booming" (Cherry Salazar, Aug. 31, 2026).

Animal health & field science: Mongabay, "Genetic road map offers hope for threatened Visayan spotted deer" (Sept. 4, 2026, based on reporting by Pippo Carmona); European Centre for Disease Prevention and Control, Ebola/Bundibugyo virus disease outbreak situation update, Sept. 3, 2026 (primary

case/death figures); Mongabay, “Ebola outbreak underscores food insecurity crisis in DRC” (Dan Yessa, Sept. 3, 2026), citing WHO.

Clean technology: Climate Tech & Clean Energy Monthly Report (originbrief.app), Sept. 1, 2026 edition, citing BloombergNEF and EIA data; Mongabay/Associated Press, “Brazil’s Senate passes rare earth minerals regulation,” Sept. 4, 2026; Renewable Watch, news items dated Sept. 2–4, 2026.

Note: The Climate Tech & Clean Energy Monthly Report references some underlying events from earlier in August (e.g., the Aug. 12 transmission corridor cancellation) alongside data first published this week. The Yosemite item draws on both anonymous-sourced original reporting and on-record agency denials; both sides are represented in the article text rather than treating either as settled.